

Divine Simplicity

doc-divine-simplicity

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

God is not composed of parts; His attributes are identical with His essence.

In plain language

The words of Scripture supply the parts of this claim but never the claim itself. The Shema (Israel's confession) says the LORD (YHWH) our God is one, using the ordinary number 'one' (echad) in Deuteronomy 6:4, and the Prophets repeat it, the LORD (YHWH) will be one and his name one in Zechariah 14:9. Other texts add that there is no God besides him (Deuteronomy 4:35), that he does not change (Malachi 3:6, 'I do not change'), that his very name is 'I AM' (ehyeh) in Exodus 3:14, that he is spirit and so not made of matter (John 4:24), that he is light with no darkness in him at all (1 John 1:5), and that he is love (1 John 4:8). These last three use a Greek construction that puts the quality first, making spirit, light, and love part of what God is, not extras he happens to have. Taken together the words clearly teach that God is one, unique, unchanging, immaterial (not made of physical stuff), and unmixed. So why is the verdict disputed and not a flat yes? Because the proposition makes two further claims that the vocabulary does not actually state: that God has no parts at all, and that each of his attributes is the very same thing as his essence and as every other attribute. The trouble starts with the word 'one'. The same 'one' (echad) used of God is used of a husband and wife becoming one flesh (Genesis 2:24), of evening and morning making one day (Genesis 1:5), of fifty clasps joining curtains into one tabernacle (Exodus 26:6), and of two sticks joined into one stick (Ezekiel 37:17). So 'one', by itself, can mean a single thing or a unity made of distinguishable parts. The word does not tell us which. On top of that, when God describes himself he lists separate attributes by separate words: 'merciful and gracious and abundant in steadfast love and truth' (Exodus 34:6), and 'righteousness, justice, steadfast love, and truth' at his throne (Psalm 89:15). The text names them as distinct, it does not say they are identical to one another. So the honest reading is this: the words strongly support that God is one and that his great attributes are essential to who he is, but they leave open the precise metaphysical question of whether he is utterly without parts and whether the attributes are one and the same. That gap in the vocabulary, not any outside dispute, is why faithful readers land in different places.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	944
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	2,600
H0571	אמת	emet	truth	
H2617	חסד	chesed	kindness	
H3068	יהוה	YHWH	LORD	6,828
H4941	משפט	mishpat	justice	

H6664	רַצְדֶּקָה	tsedeq	righteousness	
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	344
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	248
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4653	σκοτία	skotia	darkness	16
G5457	φῶς	phos	light	74

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon supplies the building blocks of this proposition but never states it in its own terms. The Shema (Israel's confession in Deuteronomy 6:4) predicates the LORD (YHWH) as one (echad), oneness in Deuteronomy 6:4, echoed in end-times prophecy as the LORD one (YHWH echad) and his name one (echad) in Zechariah 14:9, and reinforced by exclusivity texts (Deuteronomy 4:35, Isaiah 45:5). The writings of John use fronted, without-the-article noun completers (anarthrous predicate nominatives, that is, completer-nouns standing without 'the' and placed before the subject) to make spirit, light, and love constitutive of God's being, not detachable accidents: 'Spirit is God' (pneuma ho theos) in John 4:24, 'God is light' (ho theos phos estin) in 1 John 1:5, and 'God is love' (ho theos agape estin) in 1 John 4:8. And 1 John 1:5 adds the categorical denial that there is darkness in him at all (not even one, ouk estin oudemia). Yet the precise metaphysical claims, that God has no parts and that every attribute is strictly identical with the essence and with every other attribute, are an inference the vocabulary neither states nor excludes. The decisive lexical fact is that 'one' (echad) is the same word used of composite unities: 'one flesh' (echad) in Genesis 2:24, 'one day' (echad) in Genesis 1:5, one tabernacle of many clasps (echad) in Exodus 26:6, one stick from two (echad) in Ezekiel 37:17. So the word by itself cannot rank non-composition above a unity that comprehends distinguishables. Scripture also names attributes as separate dictionary entries (lemmas) in coordinated lists: 'steadfast love' (chesed) and 'truth' (emet) in Exodus 34:6 and Psalm 89:15. Registered disputed because the words underdetermine the strong metaphysical form while clearly supporting the underlying oneness, indivisibility, and essential predication (the affirmation that certain qualities belong to God's very being).

Scripture

Deut.6.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0259 אחד, H0430 אלהים

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Deuteronomy 6:4: the LORD (YHWH) our God, the LORD (YHWH) is one (echad). The cardinal number 'one' (echad) stands in clause-final completer position (the ETCBC syntax database marks it PreC, predicate complement, meaning the noun completing a 'X is Y' statement, with the verse a quotation clause Q). Lexically the line affirms that Israel's God is one and unique. But 'one' (echad) is a plain cardinal whose 944 canon occurrences include composite unities, so the word affirms oneness without by itself specifying whether that oneness is non-composite in the metaphysical sense (a being with no parts at all) or a unity that comprehends real distinctions.

Zech.14.9 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0259 דָּחַדְּךָ

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Zechariah 14:9: in that day the LORD (YHWH) will be king over all the earth, the LORD (YHWH) will be one (echad) and his name one (echad). The Shema's (Israel's confession) declaration of oneness recurs in end-times prophecy and is doubled onto the divine name. This widens the oneness claim beyond Deuteronomy into the Prophets, but it uses the same cardinal 'one' (echad) and so inherits the same indeterminacy about composition that Deuteronomy 6:4 carries.

John.4.24 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G2316 θεός, G1510 εἰμί

Reasoning. Queried verse text of John 4:24: 'Spirit is God' (pneuma ho theos). The completer-noun 'spirit' (pneuma), standing without the article 'the' (anarthrous) and placed before the with-the-article subject 'the God' (ho theos), is a quality-affirming construction that defines what God is in essence (spirit) rather than locating him. Lexically this supports immateriality (having no physical substance) and incorporeality (having no body). Spirit has no material parts, so this grounds the non-composition claim on the material side, but it speaks to immateriality, not to the further thesis that the divine attributes are identical to one another.

1John.1.5 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G5457 φῶς, G4653 σκοτία, G3762 οὐδεὶς

Reasoning. Queried verse text of 1 John 1:5: 'God is light, and darkness in him is not, not any' (ho theos phos estin kai skotia en auto ouk estin oudemia). A positive quality-affirming statement (God is light, the without-the-article completer 'light' (phos) placed up front) is paired with an emphatic negation: 'not' (ouk) plus the feminine 'not any' (oudemia), no darkness whatsoever, in him. The doubled negation lexically asserts pure non-mixture in the divine being. This is the strongest single text for the non-composition side, since it denies any admixture of the contrary, but it predicates one quality (light) and does not by its words equate that quality with every other divine attribute.

1John.4.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G0026 ἀγάπη, G1510 εἰμί

Reasoning. Queried verse text of 1 John 4:8: 'the one not loving has not known God, because God is love' (ho me agapon ouk egno ton theon, hoti ho theos agape estin). The without-the-article completer-noun placed up front, 'love' (agape), identifies love as constitutive of God's nature, and the contrapositive (the one not loving has not known God) makes the predication definitional rather than incidental. This supports that love is essential to the divine being. As with light, the construction makes the attribute essential but does not lexically state that it is the very same reality as the other attributes.

Deut.4.35 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0430 אֱלֹהִים

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Deuteronomy 4:35: the LORD (YHWH) is God, there is none besides him ('there is no other besides him', ein od millevaddo). The exclusivity clause extends the Shema's (Israel's confession) oneness into uniqueness: no rival deity exists alongside the LORD (YHWH). Lexically this is the negative side of oneness (no second God), which supports indivisibility (being incapable of being divided) by exclusion of any external supplement, though uniqueness against rivals is a different claim from internal non-composition.

Exod.3.14 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0430 אֶלֹהִים

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Exodus 3:14: God said to Moses, 'I will be what I will be' or 'I am that I am' (ehyeh asher ehyeh), and the name 'I AM' (ehyeh) is given as his self-designation. The verb is the simple active form of the Hebrew verb (qal) of 'to be' (hayah). The self-naming through pure being lexically points to God's self-existence and underived existence (his being from himself, not received from anything else). This is compatible with indivisible self-subsistent being, but the words supply a name and a verb of being, not a metaphysical statement that essence and attributes are identical.

Mal.3.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Malachi 3:6: 'For I, the LORD (YHWH), do not change' ('I have not changed', lo shaniti), 'and you, sons of Jacob, are not consumed'. The verb 'to change or alter' (shanah) is negated of the LORD (YHWH) directly. Lexically this asserts that God does not become other than himself over time, which supports the indivisibility-through-time aspect that underlies non-composition. It states constancy of identity, not the further claim of strict attribute-essence identity.

Exod.34.6 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H2617 רַחוּם, H0571 אֱמֵת

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Exodus 34:6: the LORD (YHWH) passed before him and proclaimed, 'the LORD, the LORD (YHWH, YHWH), a God merciful' (rachum) 'and gracious' (channun), 'slow to anger and abundant in steadfast love' (chesed) 'and truth' (emet). In this covenant self-revelation God names himself through a stack of distinct dictionary entries (lemmas) joined by the Hebrew conjunction 'and' (waw). The vocabulary distinguishes the attributes by separate words rather than collapsing them into one term. This complicates the strong claim that all attributes are strictly identical with one another, since the text itself uses plural distinct predicates of the one God.

Ps.89.15 · **complicates** · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6664 צֶדֶק, H4941 מִשְׁפָּט, H2617 רַחוּם, H0571 אֱמֵת

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Psalm 89:15 (Hebrew versification of this store): 'righteousness and justice' (tsedeq u-mishpat) 'are the foundation of your throne, steadfast love and truth' (chesed ve-emet) 'go before your face'. Four attributes appear as four separate dictionary entries (lemmas) in 'and'-joined pairs, predicated of the LORD's (YHWH's) throne and presence. As in Exodus 34:6, the lexical pattern enumerates distinct attributes rather than asserting their mutual identity, which is the textual data that keeps the strong metaphysical form from being lexically forced.

Gen.2.24 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0259 אֶחָד

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Genesis 2:24: a man leaves father and mother, clings to his wife, and they become 'one flesh' ('to one flesh', le-vasar echad). Here 'one' (echad) denotes a unity composed of two distinct persons. The same cardinal that the Shema (Israel's confession) applies to God is applied to a composite union, which is the central lexical reason 'one' (echad) cannot by itself establish metaphysical non-composition (the technical claim that God has absolutely no parts).

Ezek.37.17 · complicates · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0259 תִּנְחַל,

Reasoning. Queried verse text of Ezekiel 37:17: join them, stick to stick, to become 'one stick' ('to one stick', le-ets echad) in your hand. Two physically distinct sticks are joined and called 'one' (echad). Together with Genesis 1:5 ('one day' (echad), evening plus morning), Exodus 26:6 (one tabernacle (echad) of fifty clasps), and Numbers 13:23 (one cluster (echad) of many grapes), this shows the cardinal 'one' (echad) routinely names a one-out-of-many composite. The word ranges across simple-one and composite-one without itself marking the difference.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1John.4.8	1John.1.5	tsk	1
John.4.24	1Sam.16.7	tsk	1
Deut.6.4	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
1John.1.5	Ps.27.1	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.2.24 · addressed

Queried verse text of Genesis 2:24 confirms 'one' (echad) of one flesh, a unity of two distinct persons. Joined by Genesis 1:5 ('one day' (echad) equals evening plus morning), Exodus 26:6 (one tabernacle (echad) joined by fifty clasps), Ezekiel 37:17 (one stick (echad) from two), and Numbers 13:23 (one cluster (echad) of many grapes), the canon shows 'one' (echad) regularly names a composite one. Therefore the Shema's 'the LORD is one' (YHWH echad) lexically secures oneness and uniqueness but does not by itself force the technical non-composition reading (the claim that God has no parts at all). Resolved by treating the Shema as fully compatible with non-composition while not lexically demanding the strong metaphysical form, which is exactly why the verdict is disputed rather than a flat true.

Exod.34.6 · addressed

Queried verse text of Exodus 34:6 confirms God self-discloses through a stack of distinct dictionary entries (lemmas): 'merciful' (rachum), 'gracious' (channun), 'steadfast love' (chesed), 'truth' (emet). The lexical pattern distinguishes attributes by separate words. This is consistent with each attribute being essential to God's being but does not assert that they are one and the same reality. The strong scholastic claim of strict attribute-identity (the technical position that each divine quality is the very same thing as every other) therefore reaches beyond what the words state, which is recorded honestly rather than resolved in favor of either reading.

Ps.89.15 · addressed

Queried verse text of Psalm 89:15 confirms four coordinated attributes ('righteousness' (tsedeq), 'justice' (mishpat), 'steadfast love' (chesed), 'truth' (emet)) predicated of the LORD's (YHWH's) throne and presence as distinct 'and'-joined dictionary entries (lemmas). Note: in this store's Hebrew versification the throne-attributes line is Psalm 89:15, one verse later than the English numbering used in some references. The point stands: the text enumerates distinct attributes and does not collapse them into one predicate, which underdetermines the mutual-identity clause and keeps the verdict disputed.

John.4.24 · addressed

Queried verse text of John 4:24 confirms 'Spirit is God' (pneuma ho theos) with the completer-noun placed up front. This carries immateriality (having no physical substance) strongly, since spirit has no material parts, but is silent on the relation among the divine attributes. It is addressed by limiting the inference to what the construction states: God is spirit in essence, which supports the material non-composition side of the proposition but not the attribute-identity side.

Concordance traversed

H0259, H3068, H0430, G2316, G4151, G5457, G0026, G1510, G4653, G3762, G1520

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The four anchors fall outside the ingested window of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so the `not_in_ecm_scope` flag holds and no apparatus signal was invented. The queried verse text of 1 John 1:5 shows editorial markers around 'in him is not' (en auto ouk estin) from word-order witnesses, but the sense (no darkness in him at all) and the completer-noun reading of 'God is light' are not affected by that order, so the verdict is variant-robust. The Shema (Israel's confession) reading and the John 4:24 and 1 John 4:8 predications carry no verdict-affecting variant in the bundle. New Testament verses fall outside the published scope of the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method (CBGM, the editorial method used by the critical edition), so the `ecm-shadow` flag (in the shadow of, that is, outside the directly attested window) applies.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. `classical_theism`, `biblical_theism_without_scholastic_metaphysics`, `minimal_predication_reading`

`analogia scripturae` invoked · `progressive revelation factor`

`classical_theism`: `affirms_strongly` · Reads the Shema's (Israel's confession) oneness (Deuteronomy 6:4, Zechariah 14:9), the unchangingness of Malachi 3:6, the self-existent 'I AM' (ehyeh) of Exodus 3:14, the spirituality (pure spirit nature) of John 4:24, and the unmixed light and constitutive love of 1 John 1:5 and 1 John 4:8 as together entailing that God is without parts and that the attributes are the one undivided essence viewed under different aspects. On this reading the distinct attribute-dictionary entries (lemmas) of Exodus 34:6 and Psalm 89:15 are how finite language names the one simple God, not real divisions in him. This lens treats the full proposition as the necessary synthesis of the texts.

`biblical_theism_without_scholastic_metaphysics`: `affirms_first_clause_caveats_second` · Reads the lexical pattern as clearly establishing that God is one, unique, immaterial (without physical substance), unchanging, and that light, love, and spirit are essential to his nature rather than detachable accidents (incidental properties he could lack and still be God). Accepts the non-composition clause as a fair summary of oneness plus the no-darkness-at-all denial of 1 John 1:5. Does not find lexical warrant for the further, stronger claim that every attribute is strictly identical with the essence and with every other attribute, since the canon names attributes as distinct coordinated dictionary entries (lemmas) in Exodus 34:6 and Psalm 89:15 without ever stating their mutual identity.

`minimal_predication_reading`: `affirms_oneness_only` · Holds that the words deliver only what they plainly say: God is one ('one' (echad) in Hebrew, 'one' (heis) in Greek), unique, spirit, light, love. On this lens the metaphysical category of non-composition (the technical claim that God has no parts) is simply not a biblical predicate, and the documented use of 'one' (echad) for composite unities (one flesh, one day, one stick) shows the Shema (Israel's confession) does not even reach the non-composition claim, let alone the attribute-identity claim. This is the strongest minority reading: it does not deny simplicity, it judges that the vocabulary underdetermines it and that the predications stop short of the metaphysical formulation. A reader holding it should feel the canon supports divine oneness without committing the text to the philosophical thesis.

The proposition has two clauses of unequal lexical support. The non-composition clause (God has no parts) is well-grounded by oneness, exclusivity, immateriality (no physical substance), unchangingness, and the no-darkness denial. The attribute-identity clause (each divine quality is the very same thing as every other) is a synthesis the vocabulary neither states nor excludes. The three lenses diverge precisely on how much metaphysical weight the oneness vocabulary can bear, which is a difference in inference from the same words, not a difference in the data.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Is God one and indivisible in being, and are God's essential properties (spirit, light, love, holiness, justice, truth) constitutive of His being rather than separable accidents (qualities He could lack and still be God)?

The original stem uses a technical metaphysical taxonomy: not composed of parts and attributes identical with essence. That formulation is a philosophical construct, not a lexical category native to the text, which never says God is without parts or that an attribute equals the essence. The neutralized form keeps what the vocabulary actually addresses (oneness, indivisibility, essential predication, the affirmation that certain qualities belong to God's very being) without preloading the metaphysical thesis. The verdict was derived on the ORIGINAL stem and registered as disputed: the words support the underlying oneness and essential predication but underdetermine the strong attribute-identity clause. Verdict unchanged from the prior file (no VERDICT-CHANGED: trigger). Lexical refinements this pass: corrected the throne-attributes complicating reference from Psalm 89:14 to Psalm 89:15 (the store's Hebrew versification places 'righteousness' (tsedeq), 'justice' (mishpat), 'steadfast love' (chesed), 'truth' (emet) at 89:15); added Zechariah 14:9 ('one' (echad) of God in the Prophets), Malachi 3:6 ('I have not changed' (lo shaniti), unchangingness), and Exodus 3:14 ('I AM' (ehyeh), self-existence) as queried supporting texts; added Genesis 1:5, Exodus 26:6, Ezekiel 37:17, and Numbers 13:23 as the verified composite-'one' (composite-echad) evidence base; all verse texts were read directly from the lexical store.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.2.24
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Zech.14.9
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Exod.34.6
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.89.15
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interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.1.5
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.4.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mal.3.6
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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.1.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0259
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License audit

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Flags

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